



was sitting in the same class as the son of the district magistrate and other influential people. That was the time which was a big challenge for me. Studies, no matter how tough they were, were never a challenge for me," he recalls talking about the challenges he faced in his childhood.

How did he overcome the challenges?

"My goal was to study hard enough to be the best not only in the class but the whole country. I never minded anyone who saw me as inferior and I made friends with kids who were humble. I wanted to study and that was the only thing that mattered to me," he answers. Then there was a time when fellow students were lining up to learn mathematics from Manwani.

Amrit adds, "There came a time when all my fellow students started saying that if anybody would make it to an IIT from their school, it would be Amrit." His rank in the IIT entrance exam was 345 PAN India. IITs were only taking 2,000 students in its five colleges at that time, and the better the rank meant not only bettering the chances of getting into an IIT but also a chance to choose the stream of one's choice.

"The exposure to IIT, the exposure to people coming to study with you from all over the country, is extremely brilliant. Being exposed to the absolute freedom that you get at the college and hostel, and nobody to look after you is one of the biggest challenges. This is a challenge that can teach you the best of time management lessons with on-job experience," he shares.

Amrit, who refers to himself as an average IIT student, was clear from the beginning about not leaving his parents in India in pursuit of a job offer or further studies outside the country. IIT Kanpur was also affiliated to the United States situated universities such as MIT, and it was easy for students to pursue a higher degree in such universities. Amrit,

who passed IIT with 7.6 CGI, got a campus placement job offer from Larsen and Toubro. Today, he also holds an MBA degree from Delhi University, which he had completed while working with GE.

"More than 50% of the students were hell bent on going overseas for higher studies and then a job offer. I didn't have that kind of a dream or a desire. I wanted to be around my parents as much as I could. My father wanted me to start a business while I always wanted to work in the corporate world," he shares.

Father knew, Amrit realised later

As Amrit started inching towards completing an engineering degree from IIT Kanpur, the financial situation of the family started getting better. Amrit's father then asked him to start a new business in the city of Udaipur and got ready to finance the whole business for his younger son. Amrit, however, wanted to expose himself to the corporate world and learn more about business practically. He also had an offer from Larsen and Toubro (in 1972) awaiting his reply.

"My father was disappointed to hear that I was joining a job instead of starting my own business. I convinced him by telling him that to build a successful business I will need to have exposure to working in an MNC. I joined Larsen and Toubro's Bombay office and worked there for five years. My father never missed a chance to call me and tell me to move back to Udaipur to start a business of my own," he shares.

L&T had offered Amrit to join the company as a graduate engineering trainee. Amrit joined L&T Powai facility, the only manufacturing facility that L&T operated around



Amrit with US Ambassador's wife at a party arranged by General Electric

1972. Joining L&T as a graduate engineering trainee meant rotation into different departments every six months. Amrit has undergone on-job training in the electrical maintenance department, the switch-gear manufacturing department, the electronics division, vendor development, and the sales & marketing division.

"I finished the two-year graduate engineer trainee programme and was promoted to the designation of a sales & marketing engineer. The HR and training department told me that I had more flair for sales than anything else," recalls Amrit.

Here was Amrit working in the sales & marketing team of L&T, the same Amrit that was helping his father in sales at an early age of ten at the sweets shop! Amrit moved from L&T Mumbai's office to its Delhi office and worked there for around eight months before making up his mind to start looking for a change. GE, at that time, was looking to expand their base in India and Asia. The company, in the process to re-invest in India, had hired only two people from the country, and Amrit was one of them.

"My father started asking me to start my own business once again when he came to know that I was leaving L&T to join GE. It was as if my father knew that I was more of a business guy and less of a corporate job guy. I did realise the same later on," he shares.

Amrit's reason behind joining GE was to explore the international markets and the marketing side of busi-